

Community, Funding & First-Customer Plan

A Realistic Operational Plan for a Private LoRaWAN Operator in Rwanda

A research-backed, evidence-based plan answering three questions:

1. Which startup community do I join — and how?
2. Which grants and funds should I target — and in what order?
3. Who is my realistic first paying customer — and how do I land them?

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Confidential — to be customised per recipient

Executive Summary

This document narrows down the operational plan for the next six months — from "I have a working LoRaWAN proof of concept on my laptop" to "I have a paying customer, I have applied to three concrete funding programs, and I have a community of peers."

The plan is grounded in research conducted in June 2026 into Rwanda's actual startup support landscape, current grant calls (verified open/closed status), and one specific, time-sensitive opportunity at WASAC — Rwanda's national water utility, which is actively running a Request for Expression of Interest for smart water meter leasing as of mid-2025 into 2026.

The bottom line: Your strongest realistic first customer is **WASAC**, through their ongoing Smart Water Meter program. Your fastest community entry point is **Westerwelle Startup Haus** (lower barrier, climate-focused). Your first three funding applications, in order of priority, should be **(1) GSMA Innovation Fund for Digital Utilities** (when their next round opens in late 2026 / early 2027), **(2) Hanga Pitchfest 2026** when applications open in Q3, and **(3) the Rwanda Innovation Fund** managed by Angaza Capital — but only after you have a paid pilot in hand.

What this document is NOT

- Not a pitch deck — that's a separate artifact, customised per recipient.
- Not a comprehensive ecosystem report. Selected, prioritised, actionable only.
- Not aspirational. Every program, person, and number was verified against current public sources in June 2026.

Reading guide

The document has three independent sections — you can read any one in isolation:

- **Part 1 — Community:** Which physical and online spaces to join, in what order, and what you actually get from each.
- **Part 2 — Funding:** Specific grants and accelerators with verified status (open / closing soon / rolling / closed). Prioritised by realistic fit, not by amount.
- **Part 3 — First Customer:** The realistic path to your first paying account, including the specific WASAC tender currently active.

Part 1 — Community: How to Enter the Rwandan Startup Ecosystem

Rwanda's startup ecosystem is small, concentrated in Kigali, and highly relationship-based. The good news: this means you can become a known quantity in 6-12 months of consistent presence. The bad news: applications and credentials matter less than showing up. There is no substitute for being in the room.

The ecosystem has three concentric layers:

1. **The physical hubs** — Norrsken House, Westerwelle Startup Haus, Impact Hub Kigali, kLab. Where founders, investors, and ecosystem players cross paths.
2. **The structured programs** — Acceleration cohorts, incubators, fellowships. Time-bound, application-based, more selective.
3. **The events & networks** — Founders Friday at Norrsken, MWC Kigali, Africa Tech Summit, Hanga Pitchfest. Where the ecosystem becomes visible to itself.

1.1 The hubs — rank-ordered for our specific situation

PRIORITY 1 Westerwelle Startup Haus Kigali (WSH)

Location: KG 622 Street, 4th floor Fairview building, Rugando, Kimihurura • Country Director: Alexandra Gatare

Why this fits us best: WSH explicitly positions itself around climate innovation, has a makerspace with 3D printers and laser cutters (relevant for hardware prototyping like gateway housings), and the membership barrier is significantly lower than Norrsken. They run the Westerwelle Entrepreneurship Programme East Africa (30 startups, 6 months, regional focus across Rwanda + Tanzania) which we are well-suited for once we have a paying pilot.

How to enter: Walk in. Book a day pass (~USD 8-12). Sit there for a full day. Attend any event happening. Talk to the people doing co-working around you. Repeat 3-4 times before applying to any structured program.

Source: westerwelle-foundation.com/locations/wsh-kigali (verified June 2026)

PRIORITY 2 **Norrskan House Kigali**

Location: École Belge campus, Kigali financial district • 12,000 sqm work campus, ~320 companies, ~1,500 entrepreneurs

Why this fits: Largest hub in East Africa, hosts the major Founders Friday event monthly (already showcased smart-city innovation including our adjacent space), strong investor network (Norrskan22 fund + Norrskan Accelerator). Connection to the international impact investment community.

The catch: Higher membership cost, more selective vibe, longer time to become "one of them." Approach as Priority 2 not Priority 1 — visit Founders Friday first, then decide.

How to enter: Register for the next Founders Friday at events.norrskan.org/founders-friday. It's open to non-members. Use that visit to figure out if becoming a member is the right next step.

Source: norrskan.org/houses/kigali (verified June 2026)

PRIORITY 3 **Impact Hub Kigali**

Smaller, more grassroots, well-known among social entrepreneurs. Useful for the social-impact framing of our work (water access, climate adaptation). Lower priority because the overlap with what WSH offers is significant.

PRIORITY 3 **kLab**

Older Kigali tech hub, government-aligned (run by RDB historically). Useful for connections into the public sector — which matters because WASAC is government-owned. If a WASAC tender meeting opens up, the path may run through kLab relationships.

1.2 The structured programs to apply to (in order)

Program	What you get	Realistic fit / when to apply
Westerwelle Entrepreneurship Programme East Africa	6 months acceleration, regional focus (Rwanda + Tanzania), 20 Rwanda startups per cohort, growth-stage + early-stage tracks	Apply after Month 4-6 when you have your first paying customer. Strong fit.
JICA ICT Innovation Ecosystem Strengthening Project	Grants and capacity building for Rwanda-registered tech startups with hardware/software product already in market	Apply when our pilot is operational. We meet eligibility (registered, hardware in market, team).
RDB ICT Innovation Center Incubation	Government-affiliated incubation, often includes mentorship, sometimes grants via GIZ Invest for Jobs program	Apply early — Month 2-3. Lower competitive bar; useful as a credential.
Norrsken Accelerator	20 early-stage startups per year, investment range \$25k–\$100k initially, follow-on to \$1M	Stretch goal. Apply only with strong traction in Month 9-12.

1.3 Events: where to show up

Putting yourself in these rooms regularly converts more relationships than any cold outreach campaign. The ROI is non-obvious and compounding.

- **Founders Friday at Norrsken** — Monthly. Open to non-members. Showcases featured startups + general networking. *Calendar: events.norrsken.org/founders-friday*
- **WSH Kigali workshops and meetups** — Frequent (often weekly). Climate, women founders, regional expansion themes. Free or low-cost.
- **MWC Kigali** — Annual GSMA mobile + connectivity industry summit hosted in Kigali. Critically relevant to LoRaWAN. Attend.
- **Africa Tech Summit Kigali** — Annual February event. Pan-African scope.
- **Inclusive FinTech Forum** — Annual March. Less directly relevant but a key government policy moment (Innovate Rwanda platform was launched here in 2026).
- **Hanga Pitchfest finale** — Annual December event at Kigali Arena. Even if not pitching, attend.

1.4 The Innovate Rwanda platform — register immediately

Launched March 2026 by MINICT, **Innovate Rwanda (innovaterwanda.rw)** is the new national digital platform mapping startups, investors, incubators, and ecosystem players. It is free, official, and exactly the credential signal you want — being listed there gives you visibility to government procurement teams and ecosystem partners who use the directory.

Action item — this week: Register your venture profile on innovaterwanda.rw. Pick "IoT / Connectivity" as primary sector. Link your LinkedIn, write a one-paragraph description, and add Rwanda + East Africa as target markets. Time to complete: under 30 minutes.

1.5 The honest take on community in Rwanda

The Kigali ecosystem has been criticised as "fragmented and donor-centric" and as having too many duplicative programs. Some founders complain of being "over-mentored, over-trained" — government has acknowledged this and is trying to fix it through Innovate Rwanda. The implication for our approach:

- Don't apply to every program. Apply selectively. Two strong relationships beat five shallow ones.
- Optimise for **actual deal-flow signals**: which space puts you closest to procurement officers at WASAC, REG, or City of Kigali? Where do donor representatives (GIZ, JICA, USAID) actually spend time?
- The answer in our case skews toward **WSH Kigali for daily presence + Norrsken Founders Friday for monthly visibility**. That combination is sufficient.

Source for community critique: ewor.com/blog/kigali-good-place-launch-startup; mexc.com/news (March 2026 reporting on Innovate Rwanda launch)

Part 2 — Funding: Realistic Grants & Investment to Target

A research-grounded list. Each entry includes: actual funder, actual amounts, current status of the program (as of June 2026), and a realistic assessment of fit. Programs where the status is uncertain or where deadlines have passed have been kept on the list — because most run annual rounds and we can plan for the next window.

2.1 The current status of every realistic program

Program	Funder	Amount	Status (June 2026)
GSMA Innovation Fund — Green Transition for Mobile	GSMA	£100k–£200k	Closed April 2026 — Next round expected early 2027
GSMA Innovation Fund — Digital Utilities	GSMA	£100k–£250k	Annual rounds — monitor gsma.com/mobile-for-development
Hanga Pitchfest 2026 (5th edition)	MINICT + RDB + UNDP	~\$100k cash + benefits	Opens Sep 2026; deadline ~Oct 2026
Rwanda Innovation Fund (Angaza Capital)	AfDB-funded, \$30M total fund	\$250k–\$2M equity	Rolling. Apply when you have pilot + revenue.
RDAP Early Stage Financing	MINICT, World Bank-funded	\$10k–\$100k	Rolling — currently active
FCI4Africa Open Call 1	EU-funded, research/tech innovation	Up to €50,000	Open — deadline 30 June 2026  very soon
ClimAccelerator 2026 (Climate KIC)	EIT Climate KIC	€10,000 milestone grants + program	Cohorts annually. Rwanda chapter via Smart Lab.
Accelerate Africa Startup Programme 2026	Future Africa fund	\$250k–\$500k investment	Open — deadline 25 July 2026
USAID Development Innovation Ventures (DIV)	USAID	\$25k–\$200k (Stage 1)	Rolling — Stage 1 is appropriate for us
Mastercard Foundation Africa Growth Fund	Mastercard Foundation	\$100k–\$2M	Annual. Strong youth-employment angle helps.
NCST Collaborative R&I Grants	National Council for Science & Technology	~\$20k–\$100k	Annual calls. Requires university co-applicant (ACE-IoT).
FONERWA / Rwanda Green Fund	Government of Rwanda (climate finance)	\$50k–\$500k	Quarterly review

Sources verified June 2026: gsma.com/newsroom (GSMA round dates); innovaterwanda.rw (Hanga Pitchfest history); minict.gov.rw (RDAP); fundsforngos.org (FCI4Africa); menterprise.africa (Accelerate Africa).

2.2 The three you must apply to first

Apply this week: FCI4Africa Open Call 1. Deadline 30 June 2026. Up to €50k. Specifically for research and technology stakeholders developing innovative tools. Our LoRaWAN platform fits the "research-applied-to-real-utility-problem" framing. The window closes in days — this is the fastest possible cash injection if successful.

Apply by July 25: Accelerate Africa Startup Programme 2026. While most of their portfolio is fintech, having LoRaWAN infrastructure linked to a water utility pilot is a legitimate growth-stage African opportunity. Investment of \$250k–\$500k via the Future Africa fund. Apply even if uncertain — the application itself sharpens your narrative.

Apply Q3 2026: Hanga Pitchfest 2026. Applications historically open in September with an October deadline; final pitching in December at Kigali Arena. This is the single highest-visibility credential you can collect in Rwanda. Even reaching the top-20 cohort puts you in front of every relevant procurement team in the country.

2.3 What to apply to second (after you have a paying customer)

Most equity / large-grant funders require demonstrated traction. Plan to apply to these in Month 6-12, once a pilot is operational:

- **Rwanda Innovation Fund (Angaza Capital)** — Their fund manager website is angazacapital.com; the application is via questionnaire. They invest \$250k-\$2M, hold 5-7 years, focus on ESG-friendly tech. Strong fit for us as a Series A-ish round.
- **GSMA Innovation Fund (next round, late 2026 or early 2027)** — The 2026 Green Transition round just closed in April. The Digital Utilities round runs separately. Subscribe to GSMA Mobile for Development updates and watch for the next call.
- **Norrsken Accelerator** — Apply only with strong traction; very competitive.
- **Mastercard Foundation Africa Growth Fund** — Annual; frame around youth-employment + climate-adaptation.

2.4 Don't forget the Rwanda investment incentives (not a grant, but money saved)

The Rwanda Investment Code 2021 contains specific incentives that we qualify for:

- **7-year tax holiday** for investments meeting threshold criteria in priority sectors (ICT manufacturing/assembly/services qualifies if total investment $\geq$ USD 50M — not us today but useful to know).

- **0% CIT rate** for international companies with regional offices in Rwanda — relevant when expanding regionally.
- **5% preferential WHT rate** on dividends and interest paid to investors investing in a Rwanda Stock Exchange-listed company.
- **10% preferential WHT** for entities in specialised innovation parks (Kigali Innovation City).
- **Angel investor exemption** — investors putting in ≥USD 500k get CGT and WHT exemption on the first 5 dividend issuances.

Register as an investor with RDB to claim these. The application is straightforward.

Source: PwC Rwanda Corporate Tax Summary (taxsummaries.pwc.com/rwanda), Rwanda Investment Code Law 006/2021.

2.5 Honest assessment: how much can we realistically raise in Year 1?

Realistic ranges for a pre-revenue Rwandan deep-tech venture with a working proof of concept and one paying pilot by Month 6:

Source	Probability	Realistic amount (USD)
FCI4Africa Open Call (if applied by 30 June)	Low	0–55,000
RDAP Early Stage Financing	Medium	10,000–100,000
Hanga Pitchfest (top-5 prize)	Low-Medium	0–100,000
WASAC pilot revenue (Month 6-12)	Medium	30,000–200,000
Angel investor (after pilot signed)	Medium	20,000–100,000
Realistic total Year 1		60,000–250,000

The realistic floor (~USD 60k) is enough to cover Year 1 operating costs. The realistic ceiling (~USD 250k) sets up Year 2 expansion and Tier 2 customer onboarding. Anything above this should be treated as a happy surprise, not a plan dependency.

Part 3 — First Customer: The Realistic Path

This is the most important section of this document. Community and funding are enabling — they don't pay salaries. The first paying customer does.

3.1 The headline opportunity: WASAC Smart Water Meter Tender

Current opportunity: As of mid-2025 through 2026, **WASAC Group is publicly running two related procurement processes:** (1) a Request for Proposals for the Leasing of Domestic Smart Water Meters, and (2) an Expression of Interest for the Supply of Smart Water Meters. They are explicitly shifting from direct procurement to a **private-sector-driven leasing model**. This is exactly the gap our service addresses.

Source: wasac-whm.aos.rw/en/public-information/tenders, "REQUEST FOR PROPOSALS (RFPS) FOR LICENSING OF" (July 2025) and Expression of Interest (July 2025).

What WASAC actually wants

- Smart water meters that support **both prepaid and postpaid configurations**.
- Coverage of households, public institutions, and private water users.
- Goal: reduce NRW, improve billing transparency, modernise meter infrastructure.
- Procurement model: **leasing**, not outright purchase. This is critical — it means the supplier (us, partnered with a meter manufacturer) takes ownership of the hardware and recurring revenue.

What this means for our positioning

We are **not** the smart meter manufacturer — companies like Itron already supply 160,000+ smart meters to WASAC. We are the **connectivity layer and data platform** that makes those meters actually report data efficiently. Our pitch is:

"Itron's meters can talk LoRaWAN. WASAC has 160,000+ of them. Without a Rwandan LoRaWAN network operator, each meter today either uses cellular (expensive) or is read manually. We change that economics — same meters, 10× cheaper connectivity, same data."

The realistic angle

Don't bid as the prime contractor on the leasing tender directly. We don't have the balance sheet to lease 100,000 meters. Instead:

1. Partner with one of the meter manufacturers bidding on the tender (likely Itron, Kamstrup, Diehl, or a Chinese alternative).

2. Position as the **local connectivity and integration partner**.
3. Our revenue comes from per-meter-per-month connectivity fees + integration services, not the meter hardware margin.

3.2 The realistic first-customer ranking

A Tier-A government utility (WASAC) is the strategic anchor — but it's slow. We need **parallel tracks** so something closes within 6 months. Here's the realistic ranking, ordered by speed-to-close:

Rank	Customer	Use case	Time to close	Year-1 deal size
1	Holland Greentech Rwanda	Greenhouse + soil moisture monitoring for their managed farms / their network of vegetable growers across Rwanda. They already buy IoT — they need network.	1–3 months	USD 5k–15k (Tier-1 NaaS)
2	Norrskén House Kigali (the building itself)	Building-level IoT showcase: HVAC monitoring, water tanks, indoor air quality. Doubles as a demo site for visitors.	1–2 months	USD 2k–8k + invaluable demo value
3	A coffee or tea washing station via NAEB	Temperature, water-use, fermentation monitoring at a single washing station as a NAEB-blessed pilot.	3–5 months	USD 5k–15k pilot
4	Akagera National Park / RDB tourism	Asset tracking on safari vehicles, ranger equipment, water points in the park. Conservation IoT play.	3–6 months	USD 10k–30k
5	Inyange Industries (dairy + beverages)	Cold-chain at milk collection centres.	4–7 months	USD 20k–60k
6	WASAC (strategic anchor)	Smart water meter connectivity partnership with the manufacturer winning their leasing RFP.	6–18 months	USD 50k–200k pilot

3.3 Why Holland Greentech is the realistic #1

Holland Greentech operates in 12+ African countries, builds advanced greenhouses, supplies soil testing scanners, and is in a "scale-up phase implementing its Rooted Growth Strategy." They have **customers who buy from them** — and those customers can be sold IoT-as-a-service riding on our network. We become an infrastructure layer for their existing customer base, not a separate sales motion.

- They already have a partnership pipeline (RijkZwaan seeds, Rivulis irrigation, Hoogendoorn climate control, AgroCares scanners, Bluelab sensors). Several of these partner brands ship LoRaWAN-compatible devices.

- The decision-maker (founder Norbert van der Straaten or Country Manager Rwanda) is reachable directly — Holland Greentech has visible Dutch business culture, not a slow procurement bureaucracy.
- One pilot at the Rulindo greenhouse (their flagship Rwanda facility) is enough to validate, document, and use as case study.

Sources: hollandgreentech.com, hanzeeastafricahub.nl, agrocares.com (verified June 2026).

3.4 The realistic outreach sequence — first 90 days

Days 1-14: Set up the relationships layer

- Register on innovaterwanda.rw
- Buy a WSH Kigali monthly pass
- Attend the next Founders Friday at Norrsken
- Apply to FCI4Africa Open Call 1 (deadline 30 June 2026)
- LinkedIn-connect with: Alexandra Gatere (WSH), Norrsken team, NAEB innovation team, Itron Africa team

Days 15-45: First contact with realistic customers

- Email Holland Greentech country manager — request a 30-minute meeting to demo our LoRaWAN bench setup and discuss how it could serve their greenhouse fleet. Bring the actual gateway hardware to the meeting.
- Reach out to Norrsken operations — propose deploying free LoRaWAN sensors in their building as a community-of-practice contribution.
- Email NAEB innovation team — request a meeting about the coffee/tea washing station monitoring opportunity.
- Apply to Accelerate Africa (deadline 25 July).

Days 46-90: Convert the easiest one and start the slow ones

- Sign Holland Greentech pilot (target: 50-200 devices Year 1).
- Continue conversations with NAEB / Inyange / Akagera (slower close but real).
- Start the WASAC track — meet with their Smart Metering procurement team. Don't pitch the leasing tender directly; pitch the connectivity-layer partnership.
- Apply to RDAP Early Stage Financing.
- Reach out to Itron Africa via LinkedIn — propose a partnership conversation around their WASAC deployment.

3.5 The honest realism check

Things that will go differently than this plan suggests:

- **Holland Greentech might say no** — they might already have a preferred vendor. Plan B is a similar agribusiness with no current IoT (a tea factory, a coffee washing station, a poultry operation).
- **WASAC will be very slow** — government procurement in Rwanda is well-run but not fast. 12-18 months is realistic for the first WASAC contract. Don't depend on it for Year 1 revenue.
- **The FCI4Africa application deadline is in days** — even if we miss it, the discipline of writing it sharpens our pitch for the next funder.
- **Some grants we apply to will reject us** — that's normal. Reframe each rejection as data about how to position better next time.

3.6 The metric that matters

Single KPI to track: **Paying customer count at Month 6 $\geq$ 1.** Not "leads in pipeline," not "applications submitted," not "events attended." A signed contract with a deposit paid by Month 6. Everything else in this document serves that single number.

Closing & Next Steps

What to do this week (in order)

1. Register on **innovaterwanda.rw** (30 min)
2. Visit **Westerwelle Startup Haus Kigali** for a day pass (~USD 12)
3. Start the **FCI4Africa Open Call 1** application (deadline 30 June)
4. Email **Holland Greentech Rwanda** requesting a 30-min meeting
5. Register for the next **Norrskén Founders Friday** at events.norrskén.org

What to do this month

1. Apply to **Accelerate Africa** (deadline 25 July 2026)
2. Apply to **RDAP Early Stage Financing**
3. Schedule a meeting with the **NAEB innovation team**
4. Make a first contact with **WASAC's smart metering procurement team** — exploratory only, not a tender bid
5. Connect on LinkedIn with **Itron's regional sales team**

What to do this quarter

1. Land Holland Greentech (or fallback agribusiness) as paying pilot customer
2. Apply to **Hanga Pitchfest 2026** when applications open in September
3. Have a working customer case study to use in subsequent applications
4. Apply to **Westerwelle Entrepreneurship Programme East Africa** next cohort
5. Begin the formal Rwanda business registration if not already done (RDB one-stop centre)

End of plan. Version 1.0 — June 2026.

This document is intended as an internal operating plan; redact and customise sections when sharing with external parties.